

Agriculture

Social Science — Geography • Chapter 4 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Two-thirds of India lives by farming, directly or indirectly. Farming feeds us, supplies raw material to industries, and pays for our exports. This chapter looks at the variety of farming practised in India, the main crops grown in different seasons and regions, the technological revolutions that transformed Indian agriculture, and the policy challenges still ahead.

Types of farming in India

- **Primitive subsistence farming** ('slash-and-burn' / shifting cultivation) — small patches of land cleared with simple tools, depend on monsoon, crop yields are low. Names: *jhum* (NE India), *podu* (Andhra), *milpa* (Mexico). When fertility falls, the patch is abandoned for another.
- **Intensive subsistence farming** — high inputs of labour and chemicals on small landholdings; high yields. Practised in densely populated areas (eastern UP, Bihar, West Bengal).
- **Commercial farming** — high productivity for the market; uses high-yielding seeds, fertilisers, pesticides, irrigation. Examples: rice in Punjab is commercial but in Odisha is subsistence — same crop, different orientation.
- **Plantation agriculture** — single crop grown on a large area with capital and labour, processed on the farm or nearby. Examples: tea (Assam, North Bengal), coffee (Karnataka), rubber (Kerala), sugarcane (UP, Maharashtra), banana (Tamil Nadu).

Cropping seasons and major crops

- **Kharif** (monsoon) — sown June-July, harvested Sept-Oct. Crops: **rice**, maize, jowar, bajra, tur (arhar), moong, urad, cotton, jute, groundnut, soyabean.
- **Rabi** (winter) — sown Oct-Dec, harvested April-June. Crops: **wheat**, barley, peas, gram, mustard. Punjab/Haryana/UP key areas.
- **Zaid** (short summer season between rabi and kharif) — watermelon, muskmelon, cucumber, fodder.

Major crops at a glance

- **Rice** — staple of India; needs high temperature (>25 °C), humid (rainfall >100 cm); grown mostly in plains of north and northeast and on river deltas. India is the second-largest producer.
- **Wheat** — second-most important food crop; cool growing season, bright sunshine at maturity, ~50–75 cm rainfall; main belts: Ganga-Sutlej plains and the black-soil region of the Deccan.
- **Millets (Coarse cereals)** — jowar, bajra, ragi: nutritious, drought-resistant; grown in dry regions like Maharashtra, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Andhra.
- **Pulses** — major source of protein in vegetarian diets; tur, urad, moong, masur, peas, gram. India is the largest producer and consumer; pulses fix nitrogen — great for crop rotation.
- **Sugarcane** — second-largest producer; tropical/subtropical crop; UP, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu.
- **Oilseeds** — groundnut, mustard, soyabean, sunflower; used for cooking, cattle feed, lubricants.
- **Tea & Coffee** — Assam, Darjeeling, Nilgiris (tea); Karnataka mainly (Coffee Arabica). India is the largest producer and consumer of tea.
- **Horticulture crops** — fruits and vegetables; India is second-largest producer.
- **Non-food crops** — rubber (Kerala), cotton, jute (West Bengal, Bihar — used for ropes, gunny bags).

Technological and institutional reforms

Two great waves transformed Indian agriculture: the **Green Revolution** of the 1960s-70s (high-yielding seeds, irrigation, fertilisers, pesticides — pioneered in Punjab, Haryana, western UP, raising wheat and rice output dramatically) and the **White Revolution** (Operation Flood — increased milk production, made India the world's largest milk producer).

Institutional reforms over the years: collectivisation, land-ceiling and consolidation of holdings; abolition of zamindari; **MSP (Minimum Support Price)** for major crops; subsidies on power, fertilisers, seeds; **Kisan Credit Card** and crop insurance schemes; PDS (Public Distribution System) for food security.

Impact of globalisation

Globalisation has opened Indian agriculture to international competition — farmers benefit from access to global markets but also face price volatility and competition from subsidised imports. Cropping patterns have shifted toward higher-value crops (cotton, soybean) — but indebtedness and farmer distress in some regions remain a challenge.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Farming types: primitive subsistence (jhum/podu), intensive subsistence, commercial, plantation.
- Three seasons: Kharif (monsoon — rice, jute, cotton), Rabi (winter — wheat, mustard), Zaid (short summer).
- Rice — top in deltas/plains; needs hot, humid, >100 cm rainfall.
- Wheat — Ganga-Sutlej plains, Deccan; needs cool growing season + bright at maturity.
- Green Revolution — wheat & rice; White Revolution (Operation Flood) — milk.
- MSP, KCC, crop insurance, land reforms — government support measures.
- India is the largest producer of pulses, milk, tea (and consumer); world #2 in rice, wheat, sugarcane.

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